

Psychoanalytic Criticism



Pre-Think-It

- In the past few lenses, we have analyzed *external* forces and power dynamics, but how can we analyze *internal* motivations?
- Do characters in a story have to have internal motivations to seem real?

Psychoanalytic Criticism

- Psychoanalytical criticism seeks to explore literature by examining how the follow issues are represented:
 - How human mental and psychological development occurs
 - How the human mind works
 - The root causes of psychological problems
 - How the id, ego, and superego are represented

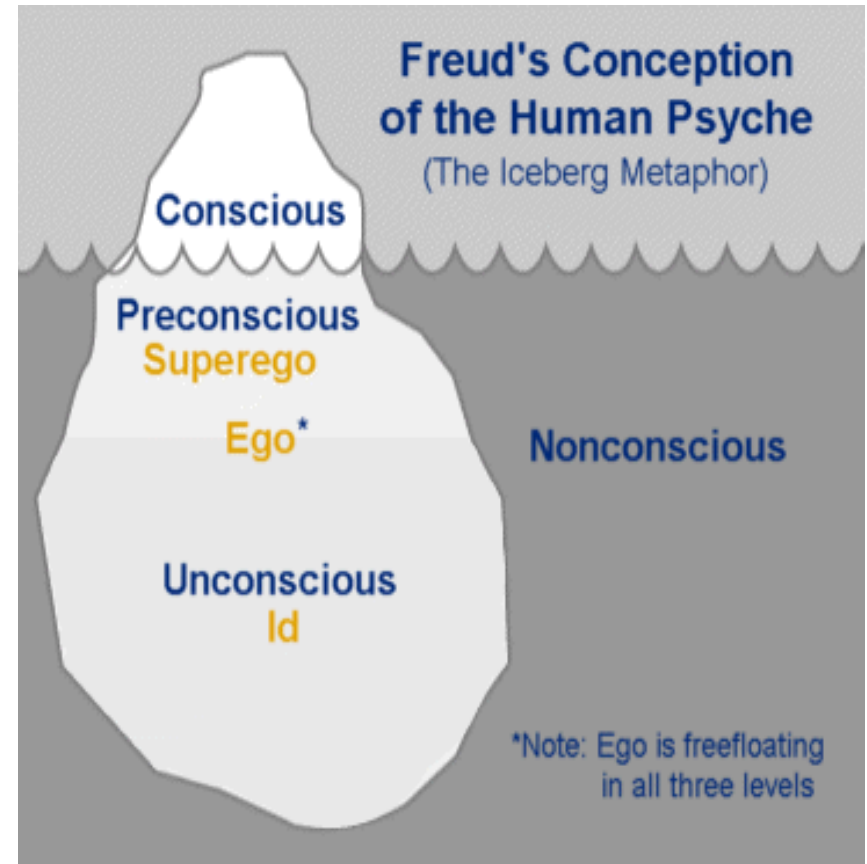
Psychoanalytic Criticism

- This information can be used to analyze literature using two different approaches:
 1. Psychoanalysis of the character(s) and their motivations as a representation of social occurrence.
 2. Psychoanalysis of the author: this often requires research of the author's life, but some academics make inferences based on the author's writing

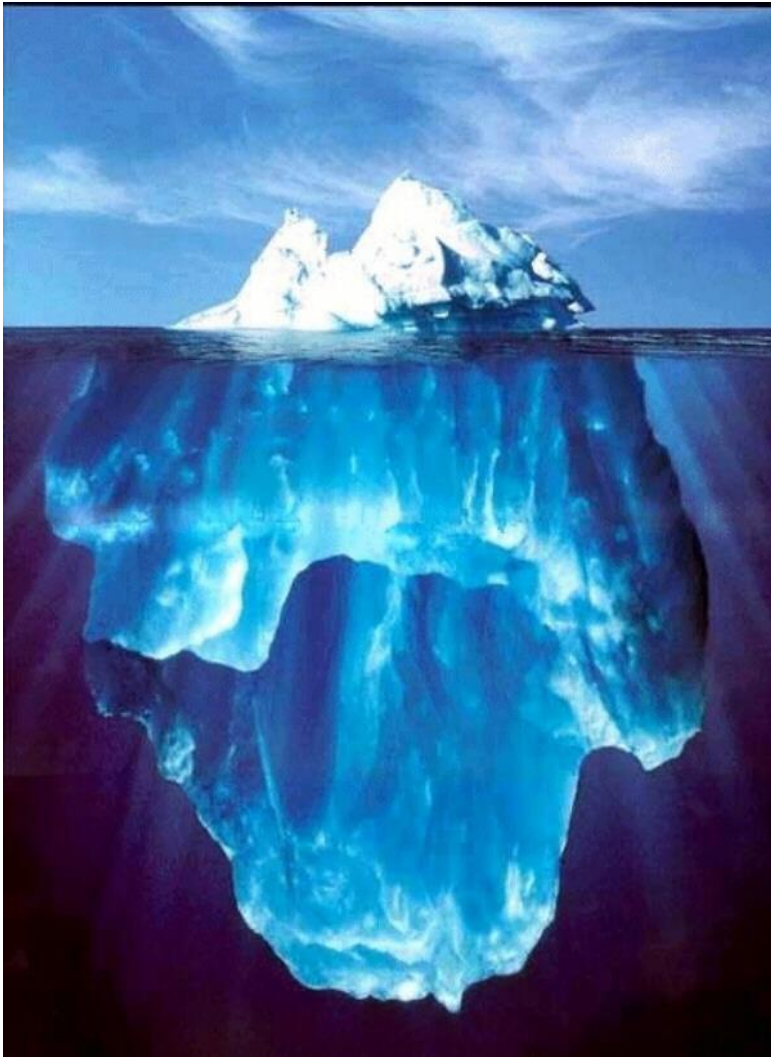
Freudian Criticism



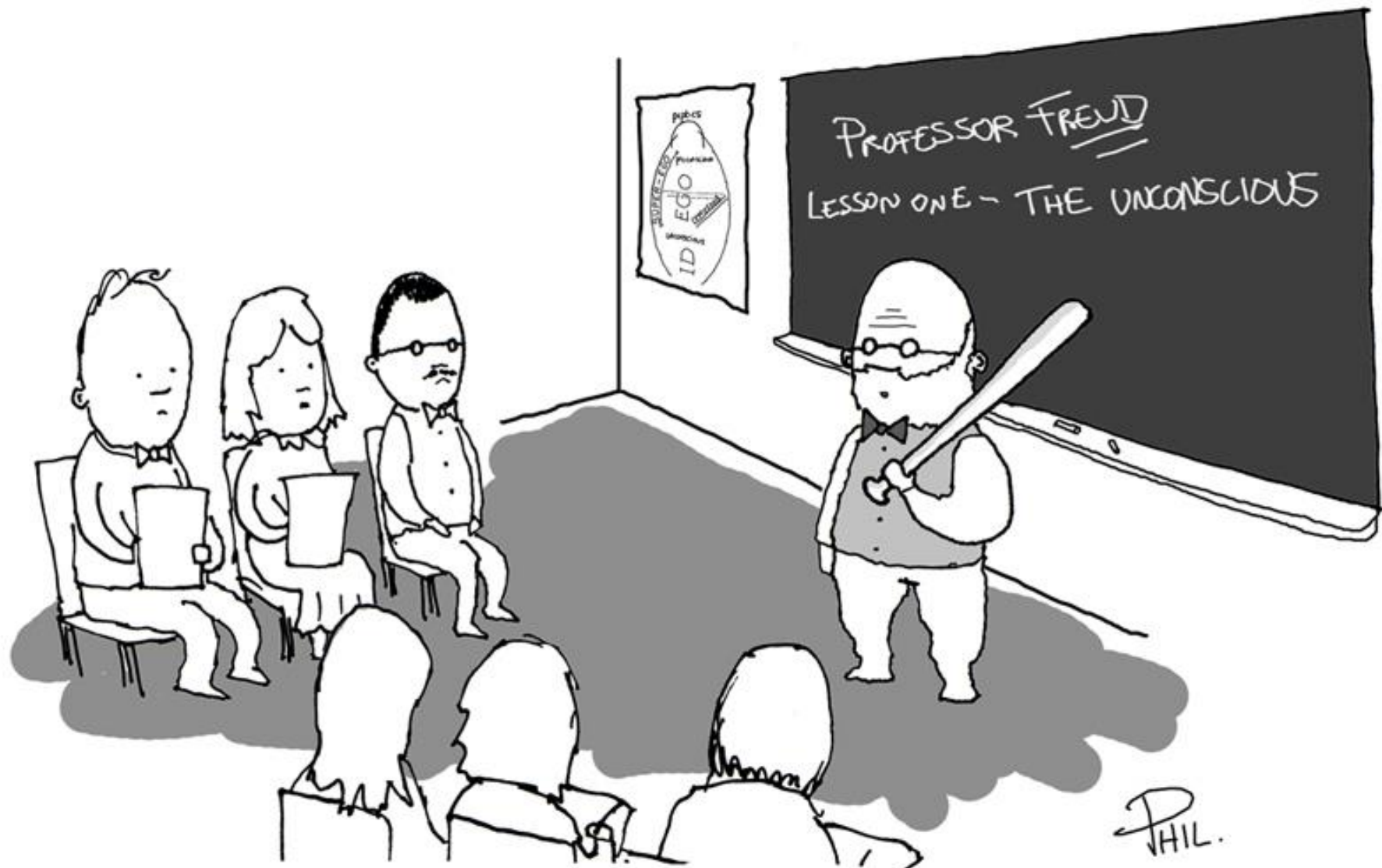
- Based on the work of Sigmund Freud (1856–1939).
- Earliest application focused on the text as a window into the psyche of the author – dream analysis
- Later applied to character and reader analysis



Our Personality

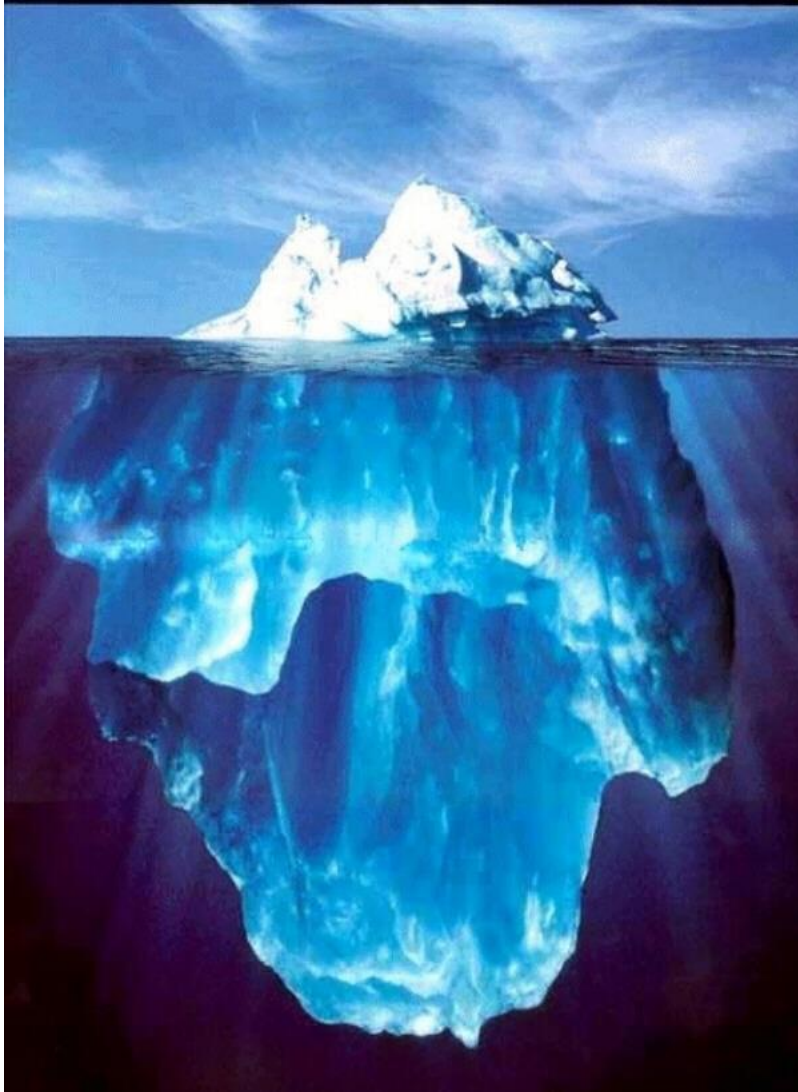


- **Conscious-** things we are aware of.
- **Preconscious-** things we can be aware of if we think of them.
- **Unconscious-** deep hidden reservoir that holds the true "us". All of our desires and fears.



“Can I have a volunteer, please.”

Freud's Concept of Personality (Psyche)



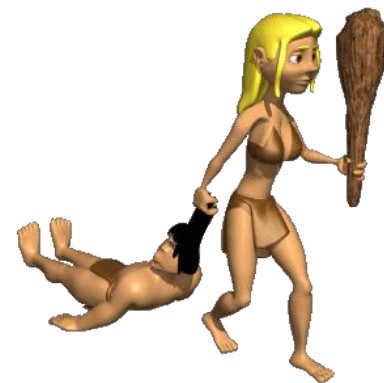
- Ego
- Superego
- Id

Made up of everything the Superego disapproves of, including rage, depression, “evil”, unchecked sexual desire, addiction, utter hedonism without restraint, etc.

The oldest mental province in the human organism, present at birth, instinctual – the drive to survive and to procreate.

Viewed ultimately as something that needs to be held in check.

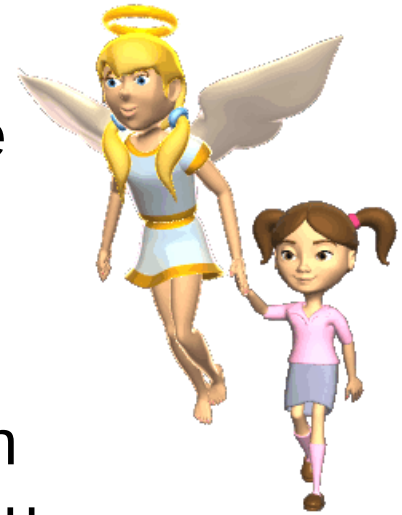
Id



- Exists entirely in the unconscious (so we are never aware of it).
- Our hidden true animalistic wants and desires.
- Works on the *Pleasure Principle*
- Avoid Pain and receive Instant Gratification.

Superego

- The mental province that responds to the demands of parental and immediate social influences (laws, religious morays, etc.) on behavior and propriety.
- The parental/patriarchal and authoritarian gaze that permeates and follows what you do from childhood into adulthood. Doing “what’s right” to the extreme.
- Develops last at about the age of 5
- It is our conscience (what we think the difference is between right and wrong)
- The **Ego** often mediates between the **superego** and **id**.

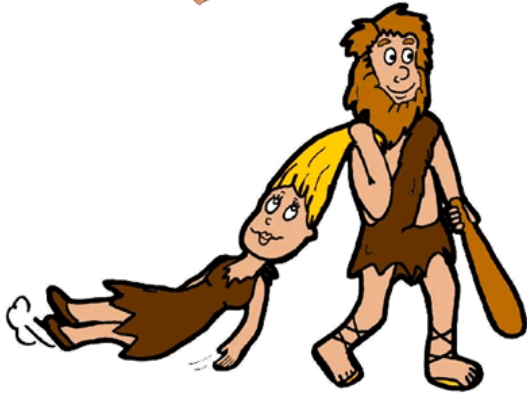


Ego



The intermediary between the Id's desires and the external world containing all of its guidelines for behavior. The ego seeks to balance the demands of the Id with the restrictions of the Superego (cultural norms, rules, moral restrictions). Also referred to as the "Ideal Self" which attempts to repress unchecked Id's desires while also allowing for acceptable levels of satisfying needs rooted in the Id.

Ex: If you want to be with someone. Your id says just take them, but your ego does not want to end up in jail. So you ask her out and make your moves.



- In our conscious and unconscious minds.
- It is what everyone sees as our personality.





Parental Relationships

- In Freudian psychology, one's relationship with one's parents is the most significant determiner of how that person will relate with other humans throughout life.
- In general terms, we tend to seek life partners that resemble our opposite-sex parent, whether consciously or unconsciously.
- Freud believed the Id desired the destruction of the same-sex parent, and union with the opposite-sex parent. (Oedipus, Electra)

Oedipus complex,

- In psychoanalytic theory, a desire for sexual involvement with the parent of the opposite sex and a concomitant sense of rivalry with the parent of the same sex; a crucial stage in the normal developmental process. Sigmund Freud introduced the concept in his *Interpretation of Dreams* (1899).



Defense Mechanisms



- The ego has a pretty important job...and that is to protect you from threatening thoughts in our unconscious.
- One way it protects us is through defense mechanisms.
- You are usually unaware that they are even occurring.

Scenario

Quarterback of the high school football team, Brandon, is dating Jasmine.

Jasmine dumps Brandon and starts dating Drew, president of the chess club.



Drew



Brandon



Jasmine

Repression

- Pushing thoughts into our unconscious.
- When asked about Jasmine, Brandon may say "Who?, I have not thought about her for awhile."
- Why don't we remember our Oedipus and Electra complexes?



Denial



- Not accepting the ego-threatening truth.
- Brandon may act like he is still together with Jasmine. He may hang out by her locker and plan dates with her.

Displacement

- Redirecting one's feelings toward another person or object.
- Often displaced on less threatening things.
- Brandon may take his anger on another kid by bullying.



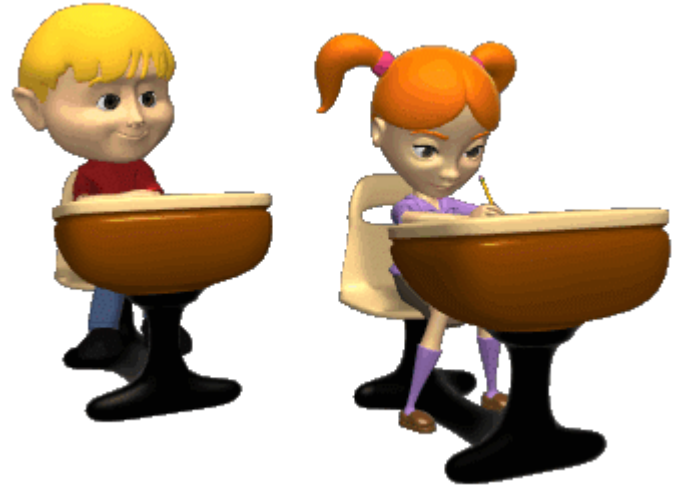
Projection



- Believing that the feelings one has toward someone else are actually held by the other person and directed at oneself.
- Brandon insists that Jasmine still cares for him.

Reaction Formation

- Expressing the opposite of how one truly feels.
- Cootie stage in Freud's Latent Development.
- Brandon claims he hates Jasmine.



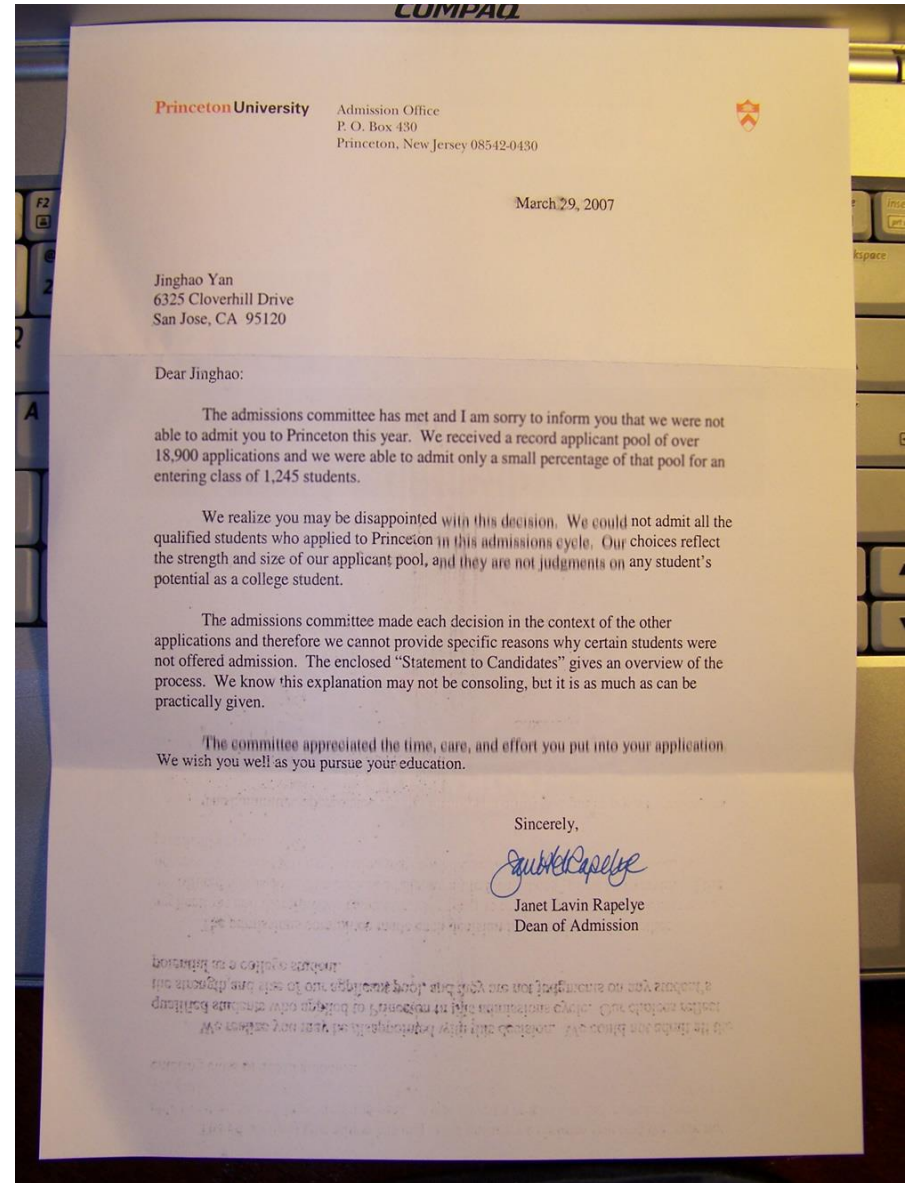
Regression



- Returning to an earlier, comforting form of behavior.
- Brandon begins to sleep with his favorite childhood stuffed animal, Sajalicious.

Rationalization

- Coming up with a beneficial result of an undesirable outcome.
- Brandon thinks he will find a better girlfriend. "Jasmine was not all that anyway!"
- I really did want to go toanyway, it was too



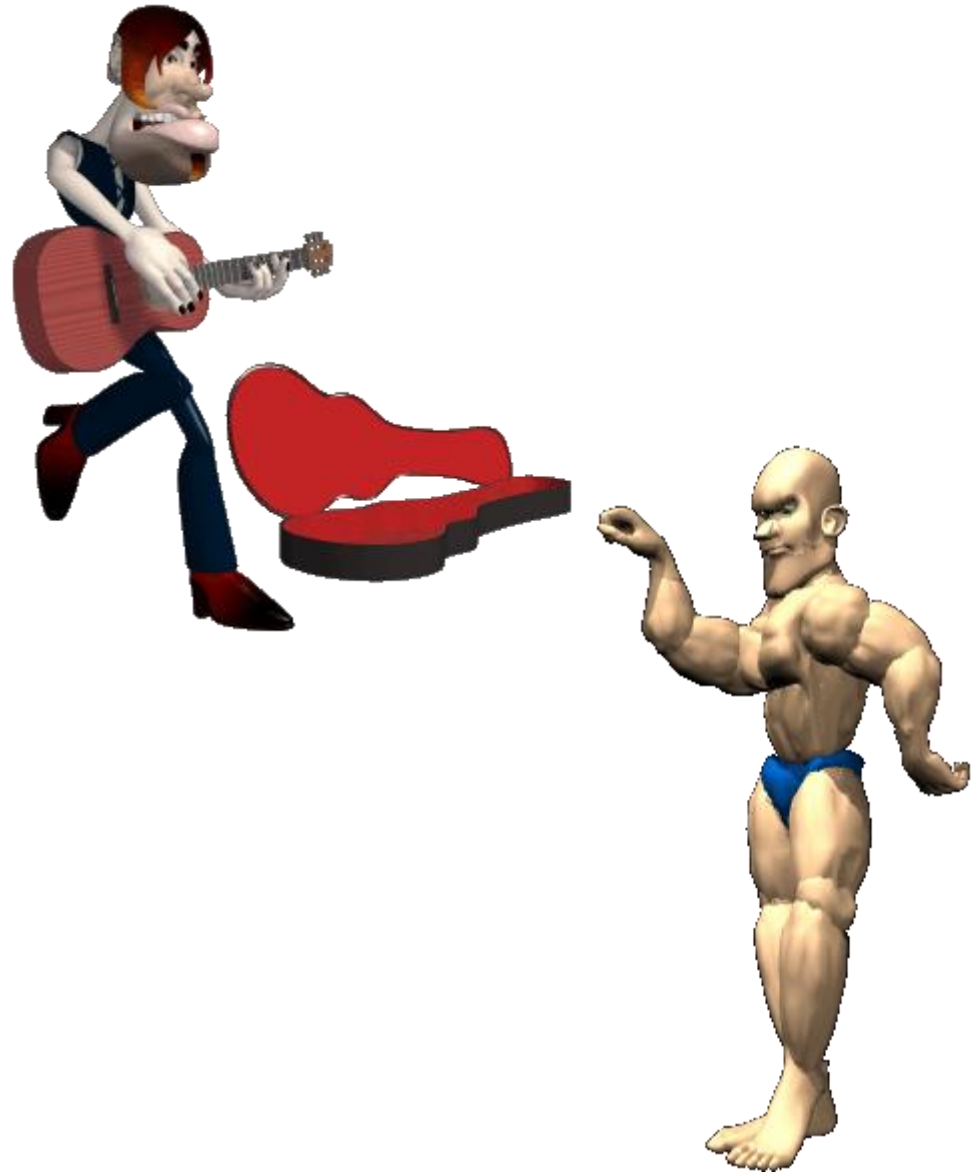
Intellectualization



- Undertaking an academic, unemotional study of a topic.
- Brandon starts doing a research paper on failed teenage romances.

Sublimation

- Channeling one's frustration toward a different goal.
- Sometimes a healthy defense mechanism.
- Brandon starts to learn how to play the guitar and writing songs (or maybe starts to body build).



Criticisms of Freud



- He really only studied wealthy woman in Austria.
- His results are not empirically verifiable (really hard to test).
- No predictive power.
- Karen Horney said he was sexist with the "penis envy" and there is an actual "womb envy".

Non-Freudian Analysis

- Carl Jung and his concept of the “personal” and “collective” unconscious.
- Jungian criticism, which is closely related to Freudian theory because of its connection to psychoanalysis, assumes that all stories and symbols are based on mythic models from mankind’s past.
- Jung developed archetypal myths and characters – Things that relate back to a history of similar representations/symbols
- In literary analysis, a Jungian critic would look for archetypes.



Psychoanalytical Critical Questions

- For psychoanalytical criticism that focuses on the character(s):
 1. In what way does the text reflect the psychosexual development of the character?
 2. Does the character demonstrate any neuroses or psychoses?
 3. Is the character's behavior indicative of or influenced by repressed desires or conflicts among the id, ego, and superego?
 4. Does the character demonstrate any unconscious, or pre-conscious driven behavior?

Psychoanalytical Critical Questions

- For psychoanalytical criticism that focuses on the author:
 1. To what extent does the text reveal the author's repressed desires?
 2. What conflicts exist among the author's id, ego, and superego?
 3. Does the text indicate any problems in the author's psychosexual maturation process (e.g. Oedipus Complex, oral fixation)?

Your Turn!

- Pick a show or a story (this could be the one from your “pre-think-it”)
- Apply any appropriate psychoanalytical concepts to analyzing the actions of a particular character (or characters) in half page analysis.

For “Bob’s Burgers”

Analyze the show utilizing the psychoanalytic lens and the following questions - a half page response.

- What is the psychological state of each of the characters?
- Why is Louise particularly upset with her father’s apparent “betrayal” in hiring Logan?
- What are the driving personality aspects for each of the characters (Id, Ego, Super-ego) and how do those aspects interact?
- What defense mechanisms do the characters utilize to deal with the conflicts of the episode.

For “Cathedral”

a one-page psychological analysis of the story.

- What is the psychological state represented by the narrator?
- What psychological inferences can you make about the wife?
- What defense mechanisms is the narrator employing in trying to deal with the conflict of the story?
- What psychological reason can you see for the ending of the story?